

'And if I did? I suppose you do not mean to accuse me of participating in my father's murder?' He asked the question haughtily, his head thrown back.

'I should like an explanation of the reason that brought you here.'

'That is simple enough. I came to see my fiancée, Mademoiselle Daubreuil.

I was on the eve of a long voyage, uncertain as to when I should return. I wished to see her before I went, to assure her of my unchanging devotion.'

'And you did see her?' Poirot's eyes never left the other's face.

There was an appreciable pause before Renauld replied. Then he said:

'Yes.'

'And afterwards?'

'I found I had missed the last train. I walked to St. Beauvais where I knocked up a garage and got a car to take me back to Cherboug.'

'St. Beauvais? That is fifteen kilometres. A long walk, M. Renauld.'

'I—I felt like walking.'

Poirot bowed his head as a sign that he accepted the explanation. Jack Renauld took up his hat and cane and departed. In a trice Poirot jumped to his feet.

'Quick, Hastings. We will go after him.'

Keeping a discreet distance behind our quarry, we followed him through the streets of Merlinville. But when Poirot saw that he took the turning to the station, he checked himself.

'All is well. He has taken the bait. He will go to Abbalaç, and will inquire for the mythical valise left by the mythical foreigners. Yes, *mon ami*, all that was a little invention of my own.'

'You wanted him out of the way?' I exclaimed.

'Your penetration is amazing, Hastings! Now, if you please, we will go up to the Villa Geneviève.'

Chapter 18

Giraud Acts

'By the way, Poirot,' I said, as we walked along the hot white road, 'I've got a bone to pick with you. I dare say you meant well, but really it was no business of yours to go mouching round to the Hôtel du Phare without letting me know.'

Poirot shot a quick sidelong glance at me.

'And how did you know I had been there?' he inquired.

Much to my annoyance I felt the colour rising in my cheeks.

'I happened to look in in passing,' I explained with as much dignity as I could muster.

I rather feared Poirot's banter, but to my relief, and somewhat to my surprise, he only shook his head with a rather unusual gravity.

'If I have offended your susceptibilities in any way, I demand pardon of you. You will understand better soon. But, believe me, I have striven to concentrate all my energies on the case.'

'Oh, it's all right,' I said, mollified by the apology. 'I know it's only that you have my interests at heart. But I can take care of myself all right.'

Poirot seemed to be about to say something further, but checked himself.

Arrived at the Villa, Poirot led the way up to the shed where the second body had been discovered. He did not, however, go in, but paused by the bench which I have mentioned before as being set some few yards away from it. After contemplating it for a moment or two, he paced carefully from it to the hedge which marked the boundary between the Villa Geneviève and the Villa Marguerite. Then he paced back again, nodding his head as he did so. Returning again to the hedge, he parted the bushes with his hands.

'With good fortune,' he remarked to me over his shoulder, 'Mademoiselle Marthe may find herself in the garden. I desire to speak to her and would prefer not to call formally at the Villa Marguerite. Ah, all is well, there she is. Pst, mademoiselle! Pst! *Un moment, s'il vous plaît.*'

I joined him at the moment that Marthe Daubreuil, looking slightly startled, came running up to the hedge at his call.

'A little word with you, mademoiselle, if it is permitted?'

'Certainly, Monsieur Poirot.'

Despite her acquiescence, her eyes looked troubled and afraid.

'Mademoiselle, do you remember running after me on the road the day that I came to your house with the examining magistrate? You asked me if any one were suspected of the crime.'

'And you told me two Chilians.' Her voice sounded rather breathless, and her left hand stole to her breast.

'Will you ask me the same question again, mademoiselle?'

'What do you mean?'

'This. If you were to ask me that question again, I should give you a different answer. Some one is suspected—but not a Chilian.'

'Who?' The word came faintly between her parted lips.

'M. Jack Renaud.'

'What? It was a cry. Jack? Impossible. Who dares to suspect him?'

'Giraud.'

'Giraud! The girl's face was ashy. 'I am afraid of that man. He is cruel. He will—he will—' She broke off. There was courage gathering in her face, and determination. I realized in that moment that she was a fighter. Poirot, too, watched her intently.

'You know, of course, that he was here on the night of the murder?' he asked.

'Yes,' she replied mechanically. 'He told me.'

'It was unwise to have tried to conceal the fact,' ventured Poirot.

'Yes, yes,' she replied impatiently. 'But we cannot waste time on regrets. We must find something to save him. He is innocent, of course, but that will not help him with a man like Giraud who has his reputation to think of. He must arrest some one, and that some one will be Jack.'

'The facts will tell against him,' said Poirot. 'You realize that?'

I had no time to develop further the appalling idea that had occurred to me, for Jack Renaud was ushered into the room.

Poirot greeted him in a business-like manner.

'Take a seat, monsieur. I regret infinitely to derange you, but you will perhaps understand that the atmosphere of the Villa is not too congenial to me. M. Giraud and I do not see eye to eye about everything. His politeness to me has not been striking and you will comprehend that I do not intend any little discoveries I may make to benefit him in any way.'

'Exactly, M. Poirot,' said the lad. 'That fellow Giraud is an ill-conditioned brute, and I'd be delighted to see some one score at his expense.'

'Then I may ask a little favour of you?'

'Certainly.'

'I will ask you to go to the railway station and take a train to the next station along the line, Abbaiac. Ask there at the cloak-room whether two foreigners deposited a valise there on the night of the murder. It is a small station, and they are almost certain to remember. Will you do this?'

'Of course I will,' said the boy, mystified, though ready for the task.

'I and my friend, you comprehend, have business elsewhere,' explained Poirot. 'There is a train in a quarter of an hour, and I will ask you not to return to the Villa, as I have no wish for Giraud to get an inkling of your errand.'

'Very well, I will go straight to the station.'

He rose to his feet. Poirot's voice stopped him.

'One moment, M. Renaud, there is one little matter that puzzles me. Why did you not mention to M. Hautet this morning that you were in Merlinville on the night of the crime?'

Jack Renaud's face went crimson. With an effort he controlled himself.

'You have made a mistake. I was in Cherbourg, as I told the examining magistrate this morning.'

Poirot looked at him, his eyes narrowed, cat-like, until they only showed a gleam of green.

'Then it is a singular mistake that I have made there—for it is shared by the station staff. They say you arrived by the 11:40 train.'

For a moment Jack Renaud hesitated, then he made up his mind.

'My friend, in many ways I have been an imbecile. But at last I see clearly.'

'You know everything?'

'I have discovered what M. Renauld sent for me to discover.'

'And you know the murderer?'

'I know one murderer.'

'What do you mean?'

'We talk a little at cross-purposes. There are here not one crime, but two. The first I have solved, the second—*eh bien*, I will confess, I am not sure!'

'But, Poirot, I thought you said the man in the shed had died a natural death?'

'Ta-ta-ta.' Poirot made his favourite ejaculation of impatience. 'Still you do not understand. One may have a crime without a murderer, but for two crimes it is essential to have two bodies.'

His remark struck me as so peculiarly lacking in lucidity that I looked at him in some anxiety. But he appeared perfectly normal. Suddenly he rose and strolled to the window.

'Here he is,' he observed.

'Who?'

'M. Jack Renauld. I sent a note up to the Villa to ask him to come here.'

That changed the course of my ideas, and I asked Poirot if he knew that Jack Renauld had been in Merliville on the night of the crime. I had hoped to catch my astute little friend napping, but as usual, he was omniscient. He, too, had inquired at the station.

'And without doubt we are not original in the idea, Hastings. The excellent Giraud, he also has probably made his inquiries.'

'You don't think—' I said, and then stopped. 'Ah, no, it would be too horrible!'

Poirot looked inquiringly at me, but I said no more. It had just occurred to me that though there were seven women directly or indirectly connected with the case Mrs Renauld, Madame Daubreuil and her daughter, the mysterious visitor, and the three servants—there was, with the exception of old Auguste who could hardly count, only one man—Jack Renauld. *And a man must have dug a grave...*

She faced him squarely, and used the words I had heard her say in her mother's drawing-room.

'I am not a child, monsieur. I can be brave and look facts in the face. He is innocent, and we must save him.'

She spoke with a kind of desperate energy, then was silent, frowning as she thought.

'Mademoiselle,' said Poirot observing her keenly, 'is there not something that you are keeping back that you could tell us?'

She nodded perplexedly.

'Yes, there is something, but I hardly know whether you will believe it—it seems so absurd.'

'At any rate, tell us, mademoiselle.'

'It is this. M. Giraud sent for me, as an afterthought, to see if I could identify the man in there.' She signed with her head towards the shed.

'I could not. At least I could not at the moment. But since I have been thinking—'

'Well?'

'It seems so queer, and yet I am almost sure. I will tell you. On the morning of the day M. Renauld was murdered, I was walking in the garden here, when I heard a sound of men's voices quarrelling. I pushed aside the bushes and looked through. One of the men was M. Renauld and the other was a tramp, a dreadful looking creature in filthy rags. He was alternately whining and threatening. I gathered he was asking for money, but at that moment *maman* called me from the house, and I had to go. That is all, only—I am almost sure that the tramp and the dead man in the shed are one and the same.'

Poirot uttered an exclamation.

'But why did you not say so at the time, mademoiselle?'

'Because at first it only struck me that the face was vaguely familiar in some way. The man was differently dressed, and apparently belonged to a superior station in life. But tell me, Monsieur Poirot, is it not possible that this tramp might have attacked and killed M. Renauld, and taken his clothes and money?'

'It is an idea, mademoiselle,' said Poirot slowly. 'It leaves a lot unexplained, but it is certainly an idea. I will think of it.'

A voice called from the house.

'Maman,' whispered Marthe, 'I must go.' And she slipped away through the trees.

'Come,' said Poirot, and taking my arm, turned in the direction of the Villa.

'What do you really think?' I asked, in some curiosity. 'Was that story true, or did the girl make it up in order to divert suspicion from her lover?'

'It is a curious tale,' said Poirot, 'but I believe it to be the absolute truth. Unwittingly, Mademoiselle Marthe told us the truth on another point—and incidentally gave Jack Renauld the lie. Did you notice his hesitation when I asked him if he saw Marthe Daubreuil on the night of the crime? He paused and then said "Yes." I suspected that he was lying. It was necessary for me to see Mademoiselle Marthe before he could put her on her guard. Three little words gave me the information I wanted. When I asked her if she knew that Jack Renauld was here that night, she answered "He told me." Now, Hastings, what was Jack Renauld doing here on that eventful evening, and if he did not see Mademoiselle Marthe whom did he see?'

'Surely, Poirot, I cried, aghast, 'you cannot believe that a boy like that would murder his own father.'

'*Mon ami*,' said Poirot, 'you continue to be of a sentimentality unbelievable! I have seen mothers who murdered their little children for the sake of the insurance money! After that, one can believe anything.'

'And the motive?'

'Money of course. Remember that Jack Renauld thought that he would come in to half his father's fortune at the latter's death.'

'But the tramp. Where does he come in?'

Poirot shrugged his shoulders.

'Giraud would say that he was an accomplice—an apache who helped young Renauld to commit the crime, and who was conveniently put out of the way afterwards.'

'But the hair round the dagger? The woman's hair?'

'Ah,' said Poirot, smiling broadly. 'That is the cream of Giraud's little jest. According to him, it is not a woman's hair at all. Remember that the youths of today wear their hair brushed straight back from the forehead with pomade or hairwash to make it lie flat. Consequently some of the hairs are of considerable length.'

character. She is a woman who can simulate great emotional stress. She is a magnificent actress. But, looked at dispassionately, her life disproves her appearance. Throughout, if we examine it, she had been cold-blooded and calculating in her motives and actions. It was not to link her life with that of her young lover that she connived at her husband's murder. The rich American, for whom she probably did not care a button, was her objective. If she committed a crime, she would always do so for gain. Here there was no gain. Besides, how do you account for the digging of the grave? That was a man's work.'

'She might have had an accomplice,' I suggested, unwilling to relinquish my belief.

'I pass to another objection. You have spoken of the similarity between the two crimes. Wherein does that lie, my friend?'

I stared at him in astonishment.

'Why, Poirot, it was you who remarked on that! The story of the masked men, the "secret," the papers!'

Poirot smiled a little.

'Do not be so indignant, I beg of you. I repudiate nothing. The similarity of the two stories links the two cases together inevitably. But reflect now on something very curious. It is not Madame Daubreuil who tells us this tale—if it were all would indeed be plain sailing—it is Madame Renauld. Is she then in league with the other?'

'I can't believe that,' I said slowly. 'If it is so, she must be the most consummate actress the world has ever known.'

'Ta-ta-ta,' said Poirot impatiently. 'Again you have the sentiment, and not the logic! If it is necessary for a criminal to be a consummate actress, then by all means assume her to be one. But is it necessary? I do not believe Madame Renauld to be in league with Madame Daubreuil for several reasons, some of which I have already enumerated to you. The others are self-evident. Therefore, that possibility eliminated, we draw very near to the truth which is, as always, very curious and interesting.'

'Poirot, I cried, 'what more do you know?'

'*Mon ami*, you must make your own deductions. You have "access to the facts!" Concentrate your grey cells. Reason—not like Giraud—but like Hercule Poirot.'

'But are you *sure*?'

I opened my eyes wide.

'But of course! Don't you?'

Poirot walked to the end of the room, absentmindedly straightened a chair, and then said thoughtfully.

'Yes, that is my opinion. But there is no "of course" about it, my friend.

Technically speaking, Madame Beroldy is innocent.'

'Of that crime, perhaps. But not of this.'

Poirot sat down again, and regarded me, his thoughtful air more marked than ever.

'So it is definitely your opinion, Hastings, that Madame Daubreuil murdered M. Renauld?'

'Yes.'

'Why?'

He shot the question at me with such suddenness that I was taken aback.

'Why?' I stammered. 'Why? Oh, because—' I came to a stop.

Poirot nodded his head at me.

'You see, you come to a stumbling-block at once. Why should Madame Daubreuil (I shall call her that for clearness sake) murder M. Renauld? We can find no shadow of a motive. She does not benefit by his death; considered as either mistress or blackmailer she stands to lose. You cannot have a murder without a motive. The first crime was different, there we had a rich lover waiting to step into her husband's shoes.'

'Money is not the only motive for murder,' I objected.

'True,' agreed Poirot placidly. 'There are two others, the *crime passionnel* is one. And there is the third rare motive, murder for an idea which implies some form of mental derangement on the part of the murderer. Homocidal mania, and religious fanaticism belong to that class. We can rule it out here.'

'But what about the *crime passionnel*? Can you rule that out? If Madame Daubreuil was Renauld's mistress, if she found that his affection was cooling, or if her jealousy was aroused in any way, might she not have struck him down in a moment of anger?'

Poirot shook his head.

'If—I say *if*, you note—Madame Daubreuil was Renauld's mistress, he had not had time to tire of her. And in any case you mistake her

'And you believe that too?'

'No,' said Poirot with a curious smile. 'For I know it to be the hair of a woman—and more, which woman!'

'Madame Daubreuil,' I announced positively.

'Perhaps,' said Poirot, regarding me quizzically.

But I refused to allow myself to get annoyed.

'What are we going to do now?' I asked, as we entered the hall of the Villa Geneviève.

'I wish to make a search amongst the effects of M. Jack Renauld. That is why I had to get him out of the way for a few hours.'

But will not Giraud have searched already? I asked doubtfully.

'Of course. He builds a case, as a beaver builds a dam, with a fatiguing industry. But he will not have looked for the things that I am seeking—in all probability he would not have seen their importance if they stared him in the face. Let us begin.'

Neatly and methodically, Poirot opened each drawer in turn, examined the contents, and returned them exactly to their places. It was a singularly dull and uninteresting proceeding. Poirot waded on through collars, pajamas and socks. A purring noise outside drew me to the window. Instantly I became galvanized into life.

'Poirot!' I cried. 'A car has just driven up. Giraud is in it, and Jack Renauld, and two gendarmes.'

'*Sacré tonnerre!*' growled Poirot. 'That animal of a Giraud, could he not wait? I shall not be able to replace the things in this last drawer with the proper method. Let us be quick.'

Unceremoniously he tumbled out the things on the floor, mostly ties and handkerchiefs. Suddenly with a cry of triumph Poirot pounced on something, a small square cardboard, evidently a photograph. Thrusting it into his pocket, he returned the things pell-mell to the drawer, and seizing me by the arm dragged me out of the room and down the stairs. In the hall stood Giraud, contemplating his prisoner.

'Good afternoon, M. Giraud,' said Poirot. 'What have we here?'

Giraud nodded his head towards Jack.

'He was trying to make a getaway, but I was too sharp for him. He is under arrest for the murder of his father, M. Paul Renauld.'

Poirot wheeled to confront the boy who leaned limply against the door, his face ashy pale.

‘What do you say to that, *jeune homme*?’

Jack Renauld stared at him stonily.

‘Nothing,’ he said.

Chapter 17

We Make Further Investigations

I have set down the Beroldy case in full. Of course all the details did not present themselves to my memory as I have recounted them here. Nevertheless, I recalled the case fairly accurately. It had attracted a great deal of interest at the time, and had been fully reported by the English papers, so that it did not need much effort of memory on my part to recollect the salient details.

Just for the moment, in my excitement, it seemed to clear up the whole matter. I admit that I am impulsive, and Poirot deplores my custom of jumping to conclusions, but I think I had some excuse in this instance. The remarkable way in which this discovery justified Poirot’s point of view struck me at once.

‘Poirot,’ I said, ‘I congratulate you. I see everything now.’

‘If that is indeed the truth, *I* congratulate *you*, *mon ami*. For as a rule you are not famous for seeing—eh, is it not so?’

I felt a little annoyed.

‘Come now, don’t rub it in. You’ve been so confoundedly mysterious all along with your hints and your insignificant details that any one might fail to see what you were driving at.’

Poirot lit one of his little cigarettes with his usual precision. Then he looked up.

‘And since you see everything now, *mon ami*, what exactly is it that you see?’

‘Why, that it was Madame Daubreuil—Beroldy, who murdered Mr Renauld. The similarity of the two cases proves that beyond a doubt.’

‘Then you consider that Madame Beroldy was wrongly acquitted? That in actual fact she was guilty of connivance in her husband’s murder?’

Chapter 19

I Use My Grey Cells

Hwas dumbfounded. Up to the last, I had not been able bring myself to believe Jack Renauld guilty. I had expected a ringing proclamation of his innocence when Poirot challenged him. But now, watching him as he stood, white and limp against the wall, and hearing the damning admission fall from his lips, I doubted no longer.

But Poirot had turned to Giraud.

‘What are your grounds for arresting him?’

‘Do you expect me to give them to you?’

‘As a matter of courtesy, yes.’

Giraud looked at him doubtfully. He was torn between a desire to refuse rudely and the pleasure of triumphing over his adversary.

‘You think I have made a mistake, I suppose?’ he sneered.

‘It would not surprise me,’ replied Poirot, with a soupçon of malice.

Giraud’s face took on a deeper tinge of red.

‘*Eh bien*, come in here. You shall judge for yourself.’ He flung open the door of the *salon*, and we passed in, leaving Jack Renauld in the care of the two other men.

‘Now, M. Poirot,’ said Giraud laying his hat on the table, and speaking with the utmost sarcasm, ‘I will treat you to a little lecture on detective work. I will show you how we moderns work.’

‘*Bien !*’ said Poirot, composing himself to listen. ‘I will show you how admirably the Old Guard can listen,’ and he leaned back and closed his eyes, opening them for a moment to remark. ‘Do not fear that I shall sleep. I will attend most carefully.’

'Of course,' began Giraud, 'I soon saw through all that Chilean tomfoolery. Two men were in it—but they were not mysterious foreigners! All that was a blind.'

'Very creditable so far, my dear Giraud,' murmured Poirot. 'Especially after that clever trick of theirs with the match and cigarette end.'

Giraud glared, but continued:

'A man must have been connected with the case, in order to dig the grave. There is no man who actually benefits by the crime, but there was a man who thought he would benefit. I heard of Jack Renaud's quarrel with his father, and of the threats that he had used. The motive was established. Now as to means. Jack Renaud was in Merlinville that night. He concealed the fact—which turned suspicion into certainty. Then we found a second victim—*stabbed with the same dagger*. We know when that dagger was stolen. Captain Hastings here can fix the time. Jack Renaud, arriving from Cherbourg, was the only person who could have taken it. I have accounted for all the other members of the household.'

Poirot interrupted:

'You are wrong. There is one other person who could have taken the dagger.'

'You refer to M. Stonor? He arrived at the front door, in an automobile which had brought him straight from Calais. Ah, believe me, I have looked into everything. M. Jack Renaud arrived by train. An hour elapsed between his arrival, and the moment he presented himself at the house. Without doubt, he saw Captain Hastings and his companion leave the shed, slipped in himself and took the dagger, stabbed his accomplice in the shed—'

'Who was already dead!'

Giraud shrugged his shoulders.

'Possibly he did not observe that. He may have judged him to be sleeping. Without doubt they had a rendezvous. In any case he knew this apparent second murder would greatly complicate the case. It did.'

'But it could not deceive M. Giraud,' murmured Poirot.

'You mock yourself at me. But I will give you one last irrefutable proof. Madame Renaud's story was false—a fabrication from beginning to end. We believe Madame Renaud to have loved her husband—*yet she lied to shield his murderer*. For whom will a woman lie? Sometimes for herself,

accepted, had the supreme art of making herself believed. Her address to the jury was a masterpiece. The tears streaming down her face, she spoke of her child, of her woman's honour—of her desire to keep her reputation untarnished for the child's sake. She admitted that, Georges Conneau having been her lover, she might perhaps be held morally responsible for the crime—but, before God, nothing more! She knew that she had committed a grave fault in not denouncing Conneau to the law, but she declared in a broken voice that that was a thing no woman could have done... She had loved him! Could she let her hand be the one to send him to the Guillotine? She had been guilty of much, but she was innocent of the terrible crime imputed to her.

However that may have been, her eloquence and personality won the day. Madame Beroldy, amidst a scene of unparalleled excitement, was acquitted. Despite the utmost endeavours of the police, Georges Conneau was never traced. As for Madame Beroldy, nothing more was heard of her. Taking the child with her, she left Paris to begin a new life.